Catholic Church didn't see them as a major threat to humanity, and some churchmen actively discouraged witch-hunting. According to the influential tenth-century text *Canon Episcopi* – which defined medieval church doctrine on the matter – witchcraft was mostly illusion, and belief in the reality of witchcraft was an unchristian superstition.[68] The European witch-hunt craze was a modern rather than a medieval phenomenon.

In the 1420s and 1430s churchmen and scholars operating mainly in the Alps region took elements from Christian religion, local folklore and Graeco-Roman heritage and amalgamated them into a new theory of witchcraft.[69] Previously, even when witches were dreaded, they were considered a strictly local problem – isolated criminals who, inspired by personal malevolence, used magical means to commit theft and murder. In contrast, the new scholarly model argued that witches were a far more formidable threat to society. There was allegedly a global conspiracy of witches, led by Satan, which constituted an institutionalised anti-Christian religion. Its purpose was nothing less than the complete destruction of the social order and of humankind. Witches were said to gather at night in huge demonic assemblies, where they worshipped Satan, killed children, ate human flesh, engaged in orgies and cast spells that caused storms, epidemics and other catastrophes.

Inspired by such ideas, the first mass witch hunts and witch trials were led by local churchmen and noblemen in the Valais region of the western Alps between 1428 and 1436, leading to the execution of more than two hundred supposed male and female witches. From this Alpine heartland, rumours about the global witch conspiracy trickled to other parts of Europe, but the belief was still far from mainstream, the Catholic establishment did not embrace it, and other regions didn't launch large-scale witch hunts like those in the Valais.

In 1485, a Dominican friar and inquisitor called Heinrich Kramer embarked on a witch-hunting expedition in another Alpine region – the Austrian Tyrol. Kramer was a fervent convert to the new belief in a global satanic conspiracy.[70] He also seems to have been mentally unhinged, and his accusations of satanic witchcraft were coloured by rabid misogyny and odd sexual fixations. Local church authorities, led by the bishop of Brixen, were skeptical of Kramer's accusations and alarmed by his activities. They